



The Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory (JCRT)

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DiffÉRance That Comes as One Unknown: Christology After Derrida's 'Structure, Sign, and Play in the Discourse of the Human Sciences'

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...You think ' because it is becoming plain to the modern eye that the ignorant love of his first followers wreathed his life in legend, that therefore you can escape from Jesus of Nazareth, you can put him aside as though he had never been? Folly! Do what you will, you cannot escape him. His life and death underlie our institutions as the alphabet underlies our literature.

The struggle to 'figure the Christ' through various means and media represents a continual search for not only the *content* of the figure in question (what makes up and makes possible this union of human and sacred) but ultimately the *form* within which this figuring is shown and understood. John McIntyre, in his Warfield Lectures delivered at Princeton Theological Seminary, begins his discussion of christology and christocentrism by employing a term not typically used in doctrinal discourse ' *shape*.' As McIntyre rightly states, "if we were asked to give in a summary form the distinguishing characteristic of Protestant theology in our time, many of us would reply that it is its *christocentric* quality which claims this title. And the evidence would be convincing".¹ As McIntyre goes on to surmise:

It is by this time clear, then, that christology has come to exercise in theology a range of functions for which it was not originally designed: in this range we find exegetical, expository and hermeneutical as well as normative and critical elements' classical christology has come under severe strain in these new settings in which it has of late found itself and a crisis has begun to develop which can only be resolved by a radical reassessment of the basic *shape* of this central doctrine of the Christian faith as today expressed.²

McIntyre rightly notes that there is indeed a continued search for the basic *shape* of this central doctrine of the Christian faith that is the nature of Christ and it goes back to the very foundations of the Church itself.

- > only-begotten Son of God;
- > Begotten of his Father before all worlds,
- > God of God, Light of Light, Very God of Very God;
- > Begotten, not made;
- > Being of one substance with the Father;
- > By whom all things were made...

Interestingly enough, the creed also presents a condemnation of those who did not 'fit' Chri.

¹John McIntyre, *The Shape Of Christology* (London: SCM Press, 1966) p. 9.

²ibid., p. 11.

> The question of the historical Jesus is such a familiar one today that it is difficult for v

> But for this task \[of interpreting scripture\] we need a method and order similar to that v

> But since these secrets \[the secrets of the Kingdom of God disclosed in Matthew 13:11; Mar

> Between religion and literature ' there is a linguistically based dispute. But it is not a c

As Rushdie correctly surmises, the move into the realm of the fictive that is represented by

a full coming together of total opposites, the opposites of total ending and total beginning,

> To enter this parabolic enactment through the medium of literature is to take on a _poetics

This statement bears striking similarity to contemporary post-structuralist writers such as J

> ...the \[Church\] lives in a strange and healing paradox disclosed' throughout the scripture

aggrandisement and self-delusion.' Yet this very same insight into the radical contingency and

Tracy goes on to say that "rather than repeating the domesticated slogans that presume to cap

the determination of Being as _presence_ in all senses of this word. It could be shown that a

This power is, on the one hand, rhetorical, yet on the other hand, substantial and real. But v

> the difference between the same and the other, which is not a difference or a relation among

"We live in and of difference," according to Derrida.' If Derrida's assertion is true, where c

> ... \[0\]ne has to go through the experience of deconstruction"[^52] to find another way, a

In the end, I am proposing a rhetorical strategy whereby one actually says more than one appe

conceived, yet passionate for the clearing act of being-in-the-world and being-for-

the-world.' As Derrida has said, the space of literature "allows one to say everything.' To say

Notes

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Updated 07/28/21.
jcrt.org/archives/03.1/keuss
